when I was attending the Battalion Support Weapons (BSW) course. Veena had become an expert at packing up a special 'kitchen' trunk, which contained all the essential items required to get going at any new place. It was always the first trunk to be unpacked and set a meal on the table in no time at all. To get to Wellington, we first caught a train to Chennai, then changed to another train for Mettupalayam near Coonoor and then by road to Wellington, where we were deposited at the Reception Cell in the Officers' Mess. Getting to Wellington had been a difficult journey, especially sourcing fresh milk for Isha who was four years old by then and for Amala who was barely six months old. I attended DSSC 47 in 1991–92, exactly thirty years after my father, who had attended DSSC 15 in 1961–62, when I was little over a year old.

When my father attended the DSSC, they were staying in an area called the Circle Quarters, the individual blocks being arranged so. Gorkha Hill, which is the main residential area now, was a forested hill. When my father attended the course, the Circle Quarters had been earmarked for demolition and they would probably have been the last occupants. When my parents came to visit, they were surprised to see the Circle Quarters still going strong. It reminded me of what Admiral Hyman G. Rickover, the father of the US nuclear submarine programme, had written in his memoirs, 'There is nothing more permanent than a temporary government building.' The TRS huts that we had stayed in at Budhwal were a testament to this statement.

The one year at Wellington passed by in a flash. We learnt the need for meticulous planning and to be able to convert that planning into flawless execution. We wrote dozens of orders and instructions covering all operational and administrative issues. All submissions were against a strict deadline and it was not uncommon to see student officers making their way

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